Modi often says in his election speeches that ‘Modi’s campaign is being done by the poor brother and sister who, under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana got a pakka ghar [permanent house], got its keys and went there to stay.’[38] The PMAY-G was formally launched on 20 November 2016. By November 2020, a whopping 17.5 million houses had been sanctioned under this scheme for the poor. Over 12 million of these approved houses had already been constructed[39] and over 1.6 million (1.4 million completed) were in UP. Just as with household toilets, these houses are not constructed by the state but funded by it. Beneficiaries (those who lived in kaccha/dilapidated houses) received DBT of ₹1,20,000 to build their own houses (₹1,30,000 in hill states) and were also entitled to receiving ninety days of unskilled labour under MGNREGS in a scheme that was funded in a 60:40 ratio by the Union and state governments.[40] Importantly, governmental policies ensured a good balance of minority groups and disadvantaged castes among the beneficiaries. Government data shows that 23.08 per cent of houses were sanctioned for STs, 21.7 per cent for SCs and 12.03 per cent for religious minorities during this period nationwide. In UP, over one-third of houses went to SCs and 11 per cent to minorities (see Figure 4.3 and Table 4.2).

The BJP did not just focus on DBT schemes; it added an extra layer of political mobilisation using grassroots booth-level organisation structures. Crucially, most of the outreach to labharthees happened outside of election cycles. In effect, the party sangathan became the foundation for a new kind of system. This mobilisation around welfare was new. ‘We always had a sangathan,’ says Sharma. ‘Now we added some new points to it. When you come to power, you learn something. This is the first time we came to power on our own at the Centre, since the government in Atalji’s time was a coalition.’

Figure 4.3: Housing Construction through DBT has Grown: Keeping in Mind Caste Groups